

Workshop: Designing an AI Mental Health Support App

Introduction

Thank you for participating in this session!

We are a group of students at **TH Köln** working on a **Requirements Engineering** project. Our goal is to design an AI-assisted mental health support application that helps university students manage stress, burnout, exam anxiety, and other everyday mental health challenges.

This session consists of **two parts**:

- **Part 1 – Interview:** Understanding your experiences, challenges, and current coping strategies.
- **Part 2 – Workshop:** Collaboratively generating ideas and prioritizing features for an ideal AI mental health application.

There are **no right or wrong answers**. We are interested in your honest thoughts and experiences.

The entire session will take approximately **45–60 minutes**.

Your participation is voluntary, and your responses will be used **only for academic purposes**.

Part 1 – Qualitative Interview

Objective

The purpose of the interview is to better understand students' experiences with academic stress, current coping strategies, and expectations regarding AI-supported mental health services.

Interview Questions

Academic Stress

- When do you usually experience the most stress during the semester?
- What are the main reasons for your stress?
- How does academic stress affect your daily life?

Coping Strategies

- How do you usually cope with stress?
- Which coping strategies work well for you?
- Are there any strategies that you have tried but found unhelpful?

Existing Solutions

- Have you ever used a mental health or well-being application?
- If yes, what did you like or dislike about it?
- Have you ever used AI (e.g., ChatGPT) for emotional support or advice?

Expectations

- What kind of support would you like to receive during stressful periods?
- What concerns would you have about using an AI mental health application?

Part 2 – Collaborative Workshop

Brainstorming

Before generating ideas, let's briefly look at some existing mental health applications and discuss their features.

Existing Applications

Wysa

- AI chatbot for emotional support
- Daily mood check-ins
- CBT-based coping exercises
- Guided breathing and mindfulness activities

Example:

After telling the chatbot that you feel anxious about exams, it suggests a breathing exercise and guides you through managing anxious thoughts.

Youper

- Mood journal
- Emotion tracking
- AI-guided self-reflection
- Personalized mental health insights

Example:

The app identifies that your stress levels increase every Tuesday and recommends establishing a weekly relaxation routine.

Headspace

- Guided meditation
- Sleep support
- Focus exercises
- Stress reduction programs

Example:

Students can choose a "10-minute meditation before exams" to reduce anxiety.

Replika

- AI companion chatbot
- Daily conversations
- Habit tracking
- Emotional support

Example:

The chatbot remembers previous conversations and follows up on events you mentioned earlier.

Discussion

After reviewing these examples:

- Which features do you find the most useful?
- Which features would you never use?
- What features are missing from these applications?
- If you could combine the best features into one app for students, what would it include?

Brainstorming Paradox

Now let's think about the opposite.

- What should **never** happen in a mental health app?
- What would make you stop using it?
- What concerns would you have when using such an application?

After identifying these issues, we will discuss how they could be prevented.

Feature Prioritization

Finally, please select the **three most important features** for an AI-supported mental health application.

Possible features:

- AI Chatbot
- Daily Mood Check-ins
- Mood Tracking
- Personalized Coping Strategies
- Stress Monitoring
- Guided Mindfulness Exercises
- Emergency Support Information
- Contact to University Counselors
- Anonymous Usage
- Customizable Notifications
- Exam Stress Support
- Personalized Progress Reports

Closing

Thank you very much for your participation.

Your insights will help us better understand students' needs and translate them into functional and non-functional requirements for our Requirements Engineering project.